of starts and I was included in the Affies squad that set off on tour to Jeffreys Bay. I was earmarked for the traditional initiation while on tour, some slapping on the back, but the same Danie Opperman was there as well, looking after me.

The 2002 season, the following year, unfolded as unquestionably the highlight of my rugby life and, to be frank, one of my greatest experiences ever. To be the starting flyhalf for the Wit Bulle through all 23 matches, to play in an Affies 1st XV that lost only one of those games, was an incredible experience.

We had a decent team.

Sarel Potgieter, outside centre and captain, went on to play for Western Province and the Stormers. Pierre Spies, our tall, quick and powerful eighthman, was a year younger than most of us but advanced to play 136 matches for the Bulls and 53 Tests for the Springboks. Derick Kuün, flanker and vice-captain, played for the Bulls and later the Kings, and captained the Eastern Cape side against the British and Irish Lions in 2009.

Heino Kühn, our scrumhalf, was also a fine cricketer: just as we were the halfback pairing on the rugby field for Affies in 2002, so we were destined to team up again to open the batting for South Africa in a T20 international against England at SuperSport Park in Centurion only seven years later, in 2009.

Jacques-Louis Potgieter, fullback, went on to play for the Bulls, Cheetahs and Sharks in Super Rugby, and then to enjoy a successful professional career in France with Bayonne, Dax and Lyon. Weber van Wyk, flanker, would become a leading cricket agent working for the Essentially Group, representing Protea players such as Faf du Plessis and Morné Morkel and always willing to assist me. Steven Botha, an outstandingly gifted wing, scored 49 tries, more than anyone had ever scored in a single season for the Affies 1st XV.

Dr Kriek was our coach and his assistants were the legendary Sakkie van der Walt and Johan van Graan, a young coach destined to become